

COLORADO RARE BIRD REPORT

RED KNOT
Calidris canutus

Red 2/2/01 wpl

7-0 (A)

Location: John Martin Reservoir, Bent County, Colorado

Date: September 4 and 10, 2000

I found this bird on the 4th while birding with my wife. It was re-seen by several birders and I saw it again on the 10th

This is a low, muddy marsh drainage above John Martin Reservoir (the same spot where the Sharp-tailed Sandpiper was later found). It has open muddy and semi-flooded flats, surrounded by grassy and reedy edges. The area was great for shorebirds the fall of 2000. I observed the bird for about 15 minutes early on the afternoon of September 4th, and again late morning on September 10th. The bird was about 25-75 yards away. I used my B & L 10x40 Elites, and my Kowa TSN-4 scope.

Description:

This was a large, juvenile calidrid. It was short-necked and plump; roughly twice the bulk of Baird's Sandpiper. It was about the body size of a Long-billed Dowitcher, though a little smaller and slimmer. Wings extended beyond the tail. The bill was blackish and the legs were dull grey. Bill medium-long, mostly straight, oddly thick at the base, and then tapering to a point. This was quite a plain bird. Above, it was dull, pale grey. Each scapular narrowly bordered by a thin blackish subterminal line, (like a pencil line), then terminally in white or pale. This gave the bird a very subtle scaly look. The primaries were blackish. Tertiaries patterned as scapulars. Underparts white with a pale orange wash across the breast. From afar, the bird was a dull sandy grey, but in the scope it had faint orange tones on the breast and belly. Sides of breast faintly streaked. Undertail coverts white. Crown and forehead finely streaked brownish-grey. Dull white superciliary. Obscure darker eyeline. Face with indistinct tan/ orangish tones.

Similar Species:

Plovers are more erect, larger-eyed, smaller-billed and do not feed by probing. Yellowlegs, Wilson's Phalarope, dowitchers, Curlew and Stilt sandpipers have white rump (and other problems). Other peeps too small and small-billed. Pectoral Sandpiper has brownish, not grayish, tones and distinct streaking on chest. Ruff has white on rump. Upland and Buff-breasted sandpipers much buffier, longer-necked, bigger-eyed and lack white wing stripe. Phalaropes too small, have smaller bills, blacker legs and do not feed by probing.

Experience with Species:

I have seen all mentioned shorebirds. I have seen quite a few breeding and winter plumaged Red Knots in Texas (and Colorado).

This report is prepared from notes made after observation.

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